7.6.2 Effects of drugs and alcohol

Short-term effect appears only for a few minutes after the intake of drugs and alcohol. The abuser feels a false sense of well being and a pleasant drowsiness. Some short term effects are euphoria, pain, dullness of senses, alteration in behaviour, blood pressure, narcosis (deep sleep), nausea and vomiting.

Drugs and alcohol have long-term effect that lead to serious damages, because of the constant and excessive use. The physical and mental disturbance makes the life of the user unbearable and torturous. For example heavy drinking permanently damages the liver and brain.

Alcoholism is the inability to control drinking due to physical and emotional dependence on alcohol. Treatment involves counselling by a healthcare professional. Detoxification programme in a hospital or medical facility is an option for those who need additional assistance. Medications are available to reduce the desire to drink and smoke.

The use of alcohol during adolescence may have long-term effects. Alcohol interferes with the ability of the liver to break down fat. Over time fat accumulation and high levels of alcohol destroy the liver cells and a scar tissue grows in the place of dead cells. This scarring of the liver is called **"Liver cirrhosis"**. Alcohol irritates the stomach lining due to the production of excess acid leading to ulcers. Excessive alcohol use weakens the heart muscle, causing scar tissue to build up in the cardiac muscle fibers. As a result, heavy drinkers have an increased risk of high blood pressure, stroke, coronary artery disease and heart attack. **Korsakoff syndrome,** a chronic memory disorder is most commonly caused by alcohol misuse.

7.6.3 Prevention and control

It is practically possible to prevent some one from using drugs and alcohol. Here are some ways that help to prevent drug and alcohol abuse.

1. Effectively dealing with peer pressure

The biggest reason for teens to start on drugs is due to their friends / peer groups imposing pressure on them. Hence, it is important to have a better group of friends to avoid such harmful drugs and alcohol.

2. Seeking help from parents and peers

Help from parents and peer group should be sought immediately so that they can be guided appropriately. Help may even be sought from close and trusted friends. Getting proper advice to sort out their problems would help the young to vent their feelings of anxiety and guilt.

3. Education and counselling

Education and counselling create positive attitude to deal with many problems and to accept disappointments in life.

4. Looking for danger signs

Teachers and parents need to look for sign that indicate tendency to go in for addiction.

5. Seeking professional and medical assistance

Assistance is available in the form of highly qualified psychologists, psychiatrists and de-addiction and rehabilitation programmes to help individuals to overcome their problems.

Alcoholic Anonymous

Alcoholic anonymous was started in 1935 by a businessman and a doctor who had been a "hopeless drunk" for many years. After the men helped each other to stop drinking and to stay sober, they then founded the alcoholic anonymous to help other alcoholics. Since that time alcoholic anonymous has spread throughout the world.

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